

She Is Enough

You can love your wife and struggle to name the last time you stopped to enjoy something about her. You could list what needs doing around the house without stopping to think. Ask what you appreciate about her today, and you might need a minute.

That pause doesn't mean you don't care. When you share a life, there's a lot to keep track of. You notice the appointment nobody made, the expense you weren't expecting, the habit that still annoys you. The things going well don't ask for your attention quite so loudly. Your wife can become so familiar that you notice what bothers you about her faster than her kindness.

The woman you love now.

My wife saves things I'd throw away. When the house feels junky, I've told her we live like hoarders. I think that sometimes hurts her feelings. There's a balance, and some things do need clearing out. Other times, what she kept is exactly what we need, and we don't have to buy it again. She has saved us a lot of money by reusing things and keeping them around.

"Hoarder" is the harsh word. The word I much prefer is thrifty. It's the same trait either way, and what I'm paying attention to picks the word. After a long stretch of nothing but work and family duty, every small thing is like nails on a chalkboard. She gets anxious when we're late or behind schedule, and when I'm stressed, that bugs me too. In those stretches, I forget what her keeping is worth.

She's getting gray hairs. She doesn't want other people to see them. I love them. She was a powerful attorney and a vice president at a public company.

For about three years she's been on sabbatical, a break from her career, to be a full-time mother. Her income has changed. Her body has changed. Mine has too. When she's working in the garden in shorts and a T-shirt, I find her incredibly attractive, and that's enough. She is enough for me.

I see her most clearly when I'm rested and have time with her as my friend. The other day we went to breakfast. We talked about life, about each other, and about things we'd been thinking about, with no kids and no deadline to race toward. My wife says the best meals are the ones you don't have to cook. An older proverb says hunger is the best sauce. Xenophon puts it in Socrates' mouth, and Seneca lived it: with only poor bread on hand, he waited until hunger made it taste good (*Letters* 123). Anything she makes is enough for me.

You have your own details. Name something true about her, and stay with it long enough to remember why you value it. You don't need to improve her in your imagination before you can appreciate her in your life.

When enough keeps changing.

Spouses compare, husbands and wives both, often without noticing. Your wife may do it too. A lot of it happens on social media. You see only what other people post, and you compare it piece by piece with your whole life. Life on the other side of the fence can look better. You meet someone who's funny, and suddenly your wife's humor is under review. Someone else catches your eye. But the one thing you've noticed becomes a new condition your wife needs to meet. What you have starts to feel like it isn't enough.

It runs both ways. Somewhere there's a man who earns more, another who's more patient, another who makes her laugh. You'd want her to remember the whole of you, and she'd want the same from you. When either of you notices it, you can say so kindly.

In Letter 16, Seneca, a Roman Stoic philosopher writing to his friend Lucilius, passes along a saying of another philosopher, Epicurus, that sets living by nature against living by opinion. Then he puts the point his own way: “Natural desires are limited; but those which spring from false opinion can have no stopping-point.” In plain words, some wants come from real needs, and they end when the need is met. Others come from what you’ve been told you should have, and they never end. Seneca’s test is to ask whether the thing you want can stop at any definite point. Neither man was writing about marriage, but you can put that test to what you want from her. If your wife met today’s condition, would you let yourself enjoy her? Or would you find the next thing she lacks?

You can notice beauty or wit without turning it into a complaint about your marriage. Your wife doesn’t need to win another comparison before you treat her with affection.

Notice what you value.

The Stoic philosopher Marcus Aurelius offers a practice in *Meditations* VI.48: “When thou wishest to delight thyself, think of the virtues of those who live with thee.”

Instead of ordering yourself to feel satisfied, you give your mind an actual task: recall something worth being glad about.

This is the discipline of enough: practicing appreciation for the real person you’ve chosen. You don’t have to wait until you’re restless to begin.

Practice before you need it.

In a 2003 study, psychologists Robert Emmons and Michael McCullough had people write down what they were grateful for. Across three studies, people

who listed things they were grateful for reported better well-being on several, though not all, measures than comparison groups, most clearly a better mood. It wasn't a study of marriages, but it's a reason to practice on purpose.

Start small enough that what you write is true. Before you go to bed, write down one thing you valued about your wife that day. Her patience with a child. Her excitement about something she's learning. Choose what you actually noticed, rather than qualities a good wife is supposed to have.

If nothing comes to mind, you haven't failed. Pay attention tomorrow. And if you're upset with her, you don't have to pretend the hurt disappeared. There may still be something you appreciate alongside it.

My family borrowed a gesture from the movie *Avatar*: a fingertip to the forehead and the words "I see you." At every meal, I thank the kids and I thank her. I think a lot of it can land as hollow, like an "I love you" said with nothing behind it. A quick thanks isn't the same as appreciation.

Then let some of that appreciation reach her. Tell her what you saw and why it mattered to you. Be specific enough that she knows you paid attention. A wife who has stepped back from a career may miss feeling important, part of a team, or valued by peers, and hearing what you see in her can help.

You can also enjoy things about her that do nothing for you. You get to love a person whose life includes more than meeting your needs.

Let appreciation become care.

"The grass is greener where you water it" is a saying I keep coming back to. I don't know who first said it. It turns the old line about the other side of the fence around. Your attention and care are the water. What grows is more of her you can actually enjoy. That can look like a kinder answer, a sincere

compliment, or time spent enjoying her company. Keep doing that on ordinary days, before dissatisfaction makes it feel urgent.

Stay in the conversation because you like talking to her. There's room in a responsible life to be glad she's part of it.

Nor does any of this require her to answer your affection on your schedule. If she's tired or distracted when you tell her, what you said is still true. You can be glad she's your wife and still feel hurt when you reach for her and hear no. What you decide is how to treat her while you feel it.

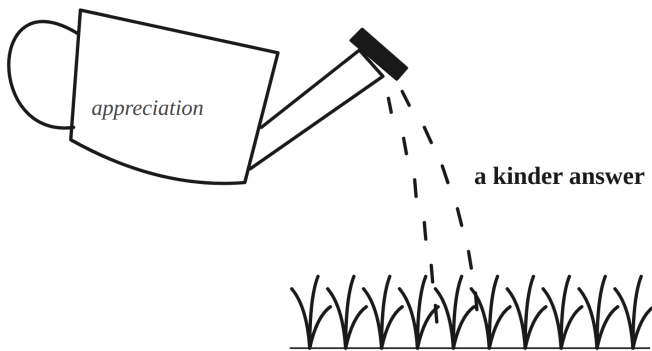
Contentment doesn't replace a conversation that needs to happen. I don't have a fixed rule for when appreciation is enough and when you need to speak. That takes judgment. You can love who she is while taking a problem seriously.

Most of your marriage happens in ordinary hours: a meal, a walk, a question about your day, the thing she saved that turns out to be exactly what you need. They don't feel like much while you're in them. They are the life you chose. Slow down enough to taste them.

Thankfulness is how you keep wanting what you already have.

Appreciation becomes care

Notice what you value in your wife



the life you share

Chapter 14 — She Is Enough

Mechanism: Appreciation becomes care

Conversation sentence: You practice enough by noticing what you value in your wife and letting that appreciation change how you care for her.

Familiarity makes complaints easy to notice. The same trait can get a harsh word or a loving one, and your attention picks the word. Comparison adds conditions a real person cannot keep meeting. Name something you value about the woman your wife is now. Tell her specifically, since quick thanks isn't appreciation, and let it become care on ordinary days. Gratitude leaves room for honest concerns and care for your own health. It asks for no particular response from her.

Lesson: Contentment grows through practiced attention and appreciation for the real person you chose.

Challenge: Name one thing you appreciate about your wife today and tell her why it matters to you, without adding a request.

PRACTICE

1. Before bed each night, write down one thing you valued about your wife that day. Name something you actually noticed. If nothing comes to mind, pay attention tomorrow instead of inventing praise.
2. When you notice something you appreciate about her, tell her what you saw and why it mattered to you. Let your thanks stand without requiring a particular response.
3. When a passing comparison becomes a complaint about your wife, ask whether meeting this new condition would satisfy you. Recall something you value about the whole person she is.